more than one generation of leaders in both states.[12] Specifically, Pakistan's rulers, both civilian and military, have harbored an irredentist claim to Kahsmir, the only Muslim-majority state in the Indian union. Even the successful secession of East Pakistan failed to undermine this claim. For Pakistan's leadership, Kashmir remains "the unfinished business of partition."[13]

Despite Pakistan's unwillingness to accept the territorial status quo in South Asia, there has been no major war in South Asia since 1971. Indeed, between 1971 and 1989, the region enjoyed its own period of long peace. This peace was based on overwhelming Indian conventional superiority and relative political quiescence in the disputed state of J&K.[14] Despite India's continuing military superiority, the onset of an indigenous ethnoreligious insurgency in December 1989 in Jammu and Kashmir contributed to renewed Indo-Pakistani tensions. Pakistan's decision makers, sensing an important opportunity to exploit India's self-inflicted wounds in Kashmir, devised a strategy to transform the insurgency into a well-funded, carefully orchestrated, religiously motivated extortion racket.[15] During this period, there was at least one major war scare, in 1990, as bellicose rhetoric on both sides over the question of Kashmir precipitated a crisis. Nevertheless, despite the stakes involved and the high level of ensuing tensions, war was successfully averted. The incipient nuclear capabilities of the two sides played a substantial role in preventing the outbreak of war.[16] By the end of the decade of the 1990s India had managed to restore a modicum of order, if not law in Kashmir. Indeed it can be argued that it was the very success of India's counterinsurgency strategy that promoted Pakistan's decision makers to pursue a "limited probe" in the Kargil region of Kashmir in 1999.[17] In this war the overt possession of nuclear weapons on both sides played a critical role in preventing an escalation or an expansion of the conflict.[18]

Thus Indian conventional superiority and the absence of any significant political turmoil within Kashmir ensured peace between 1971 and 1989. And after the outbreak of the insurgency, the incipient nuclear capabilities of the two sides induced considerable caution and prevented an outbreak of war despite a bloody, ongoing insurgency in Kashmir in which Pakistan became deeply involved.